



CARMEL VALLEY CHESS CLUB
cvchess.com · (831) 392-7456

5 Things Every Chess Beginner Should Know

A parent's quick-start guide to chess

Chess is simpler to start than you think.

Whether your child is 5 or 15, brand new to chess or just getting curious, this guide gives you the five most important things to know before you begin. No chess experience required to read this.

1 You Don't Need to Know Chess to Support Your Child

Many parents who enroll their kids know very little about chess. That's completely fine. Coach JB teaches everything from scratch. Your job is to be encouraging, not to know the difference between a Sicilian Defense and a Ruy Lopez. Your child will probably be happy to teach you what they learn.

2 Chess Pieces Have Simple Jobs — Start There

The biggest barrier to chess is thinking it's complicated. It isn't at first. There are 6 types of pieces. Each moves in one specific way. A pawn moves forward one square. A rook moves in straight lines. A bishop moves diagonally. Once a child knows how the pieces move, they can play a full game. The depth comes later, and it comes naturally.

3 Losing Is Part of the Game and That's the Point

Every chess player loses. A lot. Even grandmasters lose regularly. What chess teaches is not how to win, it's how to think through a loss, find the mistake, and come back better next time. This is one of the most transferable skills chess builds in children: the ability to fail gracefully and keep going. We call it 'losing well.'

4 A USCF Rating Turns Chess Into a Sport

The United States Chess Federation assigns every player an official numerical rating, a measure of playing strength updated after every rated tournament. At CV Chess Club, every Summer Camp participant and tournament player receives USCF membership and their first official rating. This turns chess from a casual game into something trackable, competitive, and deeply motivating for kids.

5 The Best Age to Start Is Now

Children as young as 5 can learn the basic rules and enjoy chess immediately. The earlier they start, the more naturally chess becomes part of how they think. But there is no wrong age. We regularly welcome complete beginners of all ages and watch them fall in love with the game within a few sessions. The best time to start was last year. The second best time is today.



Ready to Play?

Here's everything available at Carmel Valley Chess Club:

■ After-School Program

Ages 5–17 · Mon & Tue · Small groups of 8 · Enrollment required

■ Summer Chess Camp 2026

June 15–19 · Ages 5+ · \$500 all-inclusive · \$450 early bird before May 16th

■ \$5 Friday Night Chess

Every Friday 5–9pm · Adults only · No registration · Just show up

■ USCF Rated Tournaments

Open to all skill levels · USCF membership included

Enroll or Register at cvchess.com

Summer Camp: cvchess.com/summer-camp.html

After-School: cvchess.com/after-school.html

Looking for other adult chess players to sit across from? Check out \$5 Fridays! BYOB and \$5 and enjoy a casual night out of fun:
cvchess.com/friday-nights.html

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